# Minor Suit Stayman




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Minor Suit Stayman is an extension of the Stayman and Jacoby Transfer conventions. If you play transfer bids over 1NT, then a 2♥ response shows spades, thereby making a direct 2♠ response an idle bid. Playing Minor Suit Stayman, 2♠ becomes an artificial inquiry asking opener for a 4-card minor.

| Opener | Responder |
|---|---|
| 1NT | 2♠ |

The 2♠ response to 1NT is artificial, showing:

- 5-4 shape or longer in the minors. 4-4 distribution is okay with strong hands interested in slam.
- Interest in game or slam. Minimum strength depends on the opening 1NT range. Opposite a strong 1NT, responder should have a minimum of 8 points.
- Denies a 4-card major. Otherwise, responder should use Stayman.

Responder's minor suit length may vary depending on the overall strength of his hand. With minimum strength, e.g. 8 points opposite a strong 1NT, responder should have at least 5-4 distribution in the minors. With interest in slam, responder need only be 4-4 in the minors.

Examples of Minor-Suit Stayman hands (opposite a strong 1NT opener):

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| ♠A2 | ♠3 | ♠7 |
| ♥KJ2 | ♥JT3 | ♥K2 |
| ♦KT98 | ♦KT98 | ♦KQ953 |
| ♣AJ83 | ♣A9832 | ♣A8765 |

## Opener's Rebids

After hearing 2♠ response, opener's rebids are as follows. Note that unlike regular Stayman, opener has some latitude in judging whether to reveal a 4-card suit. Specifically, opener is allowed to bid 3♥/♠ with a major suit control and a 4-card minor. This is because identifying a minor-suit fit may be less important than reaching a good 3NT contract.

| Rebid | Meaning |
|---|---|
| 2NT | Denies a 4-card minor. Implies stoppers in both major suits. |
| 3♣ | Shows 4+ clubs. With 4-4 shape in the minors, opener should bid 3♣. |
| 3♦ | Shows 4+ diamonds. (Denies 4+ clubs.) |
| 3♥ | Shows a heart stopper, and invites partner to bid 3NT with a spade control. Forcing. Opener may have a 4-card minor with highly balanced shape and strength, and merely looking to see if 3NT is the best fit. |
| 3♠ | Shows a spade stopper, and invites partner to bid 3NT with a heart control. Forcing. Opener may have a 4-card minor with highly balanced shape and strength, and merely looking to see if 3NT is the best fit. |
| 3NT | Denies a 4-card minor. Shows maximum strength with stoppers in both major suits. |
| 4♣ | Shows 4+ clubs and maximum strength. |

| | |
|---|---|
| 4♦ | Shows 4+ diamonds and maximum strength. |

## Responder's Rebids

Most of responder's rebids are natural. The exception is bidding a new major suit, which shows a singleton or void. For the sake of completeness, though, below are all of responder's rebids based on opener's rebid.

### After Opener Rebids 2NT

| Responder's Rebid | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Pass | Minimum strength, relatively balanced. Probably 5-4 in the minors. Responder should bid a minor with 5-5 distribution (or longer.) |
| 3♣ | Natural and non-forcing with 5+ clubs. Suggests 5 diamonds because opener is allowed to run to 3♦. |
| 3♦ | Natural and non-forcing with 5+ diamonds. Opener is expected to pass. |
| 3♥ | A singleton or void in hearts with slam interest. Forcing. |
| 3♠ | A singleton or void in spades with slam interest. Forcing. |
| 3NT | To play. |
| 4♣ | Strong and forcing with 5+ clubs. |
| 4♦ | Strong and forcing with 5+ diamonds. |

### After Opener Rebids 3♣

| Responder's Rebid | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Pass | Minimum strength. |
| 3♦ | Strong and forcing with 5+ diamonds. |
| 3♥ | A singleton or void in hearts with slam interest. Forcing. |
| 3♠ | A singleton or void in spades with slam interest. Forcing. |
| 3NT | Natural and non-forcing. Responder may be something like 2-2-5-4 shape and willing to stop in no-trumps. |
| 4♣ | Natural and invitational to 5♣. Shows unbalanced shape because it bypasses 3NT. |
| 4♦ | Open for partnership discussion. Could be a cuebid with interest in a diamond slam, OR natural and forcing with 5+ diamonds. |

### After Opener Rebids 3♦

| Responder's Rebid | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Pass | Minimum strength. |
| 3♥ | A singleton or void in hearts with slam interest. Forcing. |
| 3♠ | A singleton or void in spades with slam interest. Forcing. |
| 3NT | Natural and non-forcing. Responder may be something like 2-2-4-5 shape and willing to stop in no-trumps. |
| 4♣ | Open for partnership discussion. Could be a cuebid with interest in a club slam, OR natural and forcing with 5+ diamonds. |
| 4♦ | Natural and invitational to 5♦. Shows unbalanced shape because it bypasses 3NT. |

### After Opener Rebids 3♥

| Responder's Rebid | Meaning |
|---|---|
| 3♠ | A singleton or void in spades with slam interest. Forcing. |
| 3NT | To play. |
| 4♣ | Natural and forcing with 5+ clubs. |
| 4♦ | Natural and forcing with 5+ diamonds. |

**After Opener Rebids 3♠**

| Responder's Rebid | Meaning |
|---|---|
| 3NT | To play. |
| 4♣ | Natural and forcing with 5+ clubs. |
| 4♦ | Natural and forcing with 5+ diamonds. |
| 4♥ | A singleton or void in hearts with slam interest. Forcing. |

# Examples

The following examples assume a 15-17 1NT opening bid. You can of course tailor Minor Suit Stayman to fit your own 1NT range.

| Opener | Responder |
|---|---|
| ♠KT93 | ♠5 |
| ♥AK74 | ♥63 |
| ♦J83 | ♦AT542 |
| ♣A5 | ♣KJ832 |

| Opener | Responder |
|---|---|
| 1NT | 2♠ (1) |
| 2NT (2) | Pass |

1. Minor Suit Stayman
2. Denies a 4-card minor and suggests minimum strength.

| Opener | Responder |
|---|---|
| ♠J95 | ♠AK3 |
| ♥A92 | ♥K3 |
| ♦AQ8 | ♦KJ52 |
| ♣A932 | ♣QJT4 |

| Opener | Responder |
|---|---|
| 1NT | 2♠ (1) |
| 3♣ (2) | 4NT (3) |
| 5♦ (4) | 6♣ |

1. Minor Suit Stayman
2. Showing 4+ clubs
3. 1430 Roman Key Card Blackwood
4. 3 key cards
5. Signoff. It's worth pointing out that clubs as trumps will yield an extra ruffing trick compared to 6NT.

| Opener | Responder |
|---|---|
| ♠AKQ | ♠8 |
| ♥J54 | ♥AT3 |
| ♦KQ5 | ♦A7632 |
| ♣J983 | ♣A752 |

| Opener | Responder |
|---|---|
| 1NT | 2♠ (1) |
| 3♠ (2) | 3NT(3) |

1. Minor Suit Stayman
2. Showing a spade stopper and asking responder for a heart control. Note the decision to bypass 3♣ with 4-3-3-3 shape and a bad suit.
3. Natural, promising a heart stopper.

## Additional Considerations

### Over a 2NT Opening Bid

You can also play Minor Suit Stayman after a 2NT opening bid. In that case, 3♠ is game-forcing with 4-4 minors or longer. Responder should have slam interest since opener's reply might bypass 3NT.

### In Competition

If the opponents **double** 2♠, opener can:

- Make her normal conventional rebid.
- Redouble for penalties with a strong 4-card spade suit.

If the opponents **bid** over 2♠, opener can:

- Make her normal conventional rebid, if possible.
- Double for penalties.
- Pass with a minimum.

## See also

- Crawling Stayman
  A convention for showing a weak hand with 4-4 shape in the majors.
- Double-Barreled Stayman
  A convention for distinguishing non-forcing and forcing Stayman hands.
- Garbage Stayman
  A method of showing a weak 3-suiter short in clubs.
- Keri Response to 1NT
  A scientific alternative to Stayman by expert Ron Klinger.
- Puppet Stayman
  A variant of Stayman for identifying 5-3 major-suit fits.
- Smolen
  An extension of Stayman for showing 5-4 shape in the majors.